sixth century CE with later interpolations. It tells how a king of Kalinga named Indradyumna got to hear of a deity being worshipped in secret in the forests by a tribal king named Viswavasu. A Brahmin named Vidyapati was sent to find this deity but had no success until he won Viswavasu's confidence by marrying his daughter. The tribal king then agreed to take the Brahmin to see the deity but insisted that he wear a blindfold. However, Vidyapati outwitted Viswavasu by dropping mustard seeds on the way, and when these had grown into shoots he was able to retrace his footsteps to a cave, where he found the deity in the form of Neela Madhava, or 'Blue Vishnu'. On hearing the news, King Indradyumna hurried to the cave to worship the deity, only to find it gone and the entire area covered in sand. Deeply disappointed, he began a death fast, as well as performing the ancient horse sacrifice and building a temple to Lord Vishnu at Puri. He then had a dream in which Lord Jagannath appeared and told him to seek out a fragrant-scented tree on the sea-shore. This he found on the beach at Puri in the form of the trunk of a *neem* tree, from which he fashioned three wooden images – Krishna as Jagannath, 'lord of the universe', his brother Balabhadra and his sister Subhadra – which he duly installed in his temple.

This myth highlights the possibly tribal and non-Vedic origins of the deity, its formlessness and the three *murti*s cut from wood to give that formlessness shape. An engraving of the dressing of Sri Jagannath published in 1869 (see page 223) shows that the deity's face is a painted mask dominated by two huge eyes and that the humanoid hands and feet are stuck on to projections from a wooden core, known as *daru*. The Jagannath *daru* is the largest of the three *murti*s, being nearly 6 feet in height, with his arms spanning 12 feet, and so heavy that it takes more than fifty men to lift him. Balabhadra is slightly smaller but still 12 feet from finger-tip to finger-tip, and Subadhra smaller still at 5 feet.